

Vibrant Life

Family Playbook • 2026-2027

A place where learners grow brave, families grow connected, and purpose comes alive.

Welcome to the adventure. - Jenna

Our Mission

To inspire each person who enters our doors to find a calling and change the world. We empower families to grow - and grow together - and prepare learners to hear a call to adventure and begin a Hero's Journey.

Every child is born with a gift. This journey isn't just about learning. It's about becoming.

★ Welcome to the Playbook

This isn't a rulebook. It's a guide - a shared understanding of how we move through this journey together as families, learners, and guides. It will keep evolving as we change.

These are the things we are committed to, and here is why. You do not have to adopt them. You do have to know them, so your choice is a real one. And we will keep thinking about them together, all year.

We made it to help you feel grounded, to build clarity and trust, and to honor the heart of what we're building.

Reflect with us: What do you appreciate about your own education? How does family culture help shape a child's beliefs about learning and growth?



Watch: Welcome to Vibrant Life (60-90s)

The mission, our language, and the promise.

✓ What We Stand For

1. **Learners are whole people.** They arrive with creativity, emotions, curiosity, and voice. They are geniuses.
2. **Families are partners and the primary educators.** Parents hold the primary responsibility; we walk beside you and support it.
3. **The learning environment matters.** Inspiring spaces where learners feel safe, challenged, and have a voice.
4. **Purpose leads the way.** We help learners discover who they are and what they're called to bring to the world.

What we hold, and what's yours: because families are the primary educators, we keep our focus on academics, character, emotional development, and community. We don't instruct on charged political topics, human sexuality, or gender identity - families guide those at home - and we respect each family's economic, political, and religious freedom.

How to use this book: Read it. Use it. Revisit it. If you ask a question we've answered here, we'll lovingly guide you back to it - that's the learner-led way.

☰ Philosophy & Program at a Glance

How (not what) to think. We help young people learn how to think, not what to think. We do focused core work to master foundations and lean into real-world learning, so core skills surface through projects, play, and community.

Program model. An accredited Acton Academy, part-time with a wellness niche. Your membership includes the curriculum and materials - no buying extra or teaching at home. Older studios do some self-directed work at home with built-in instruction.

★ Learning to Learn, Do & Be

Learn

processes & habits of critical thinking

Do

skills, academics & real-world action

Be

character & matters of the heart

"We delight in the beauty of the butterfly but rarely admit the changes it has gone through to achieve that beauty."
- Maya Angelou The most important part of the Hero's Journey isn't the Grail - it's how the hero is changed along the way.

Reflect with us: What family habits have etched positive character into your life? What energy-draining habits do you want to transform?

⊕ The Rules: We Play as a Team

The learner-led way is best thought of as a **game**. Imagine you're playing soccer and someone starts using their hands - are you still playing soccer? Vibrant Life is **different by design**. Clear agreements let us serve your family well. Guides and Jenna hold three **guardrails**:

Hold Studio Sacred

Be Kind & Respectful

Minimize Distraction

Each learner also agrees to studio **commitments** - integrity, respect & communication, excellence, inner work, community, and responsibility - until the tribe writes its own Session-1 contract.

What a Guide promises you

"If you change the way you look at things, the things you look at change." - Wayne Dyer

- To see your child as a genius with a gift to offer the world.
- To turn responsibility over to the learners as fast as they're ready.
- To hold the studio guardrails that keep everyone safe.
- To answer with Socratic questions, not answers - so the accomplishment stays the learner's.
- To celebrate effort and progress, and stay on their own Hero's Journey right alongside your child.

🏠 Fields of Play: Our Studios

Mixed-age studios with a shared vision. Learners are grouped by readiness, not strictly by age - increasingly learner-led from Tots up.

Tots Tribe

3-4

Play and experience are the child's important work. Welcome circle, movement, nature, practical-life skills, story. This year: a four-part parent recognition arc (Safe Base, Steady Hand, Witness, Held-Then-Let-Go).

Spark

5-7

Curiosity and purposeful play growing into self-directed work: early reading and writing, Montessori math, nature and science, low-tech Quests. Grows kindness, courage, and the first tools for big feelings.

Discovery

8-10

Quests blending science, art, math, and writing into a public exhibition; a writing workshop; deep reading; Socratic history. Grows goal-setting and owning results.

Adventure

11-14

Longer Quests in STEM, arts, and entrepreneurship; primary-source history; science labs; apprenticeships; badges. Grows servant-leadership, feedback, and grit.

Launch Pad

15-18 • soon

Know who you are, trust your capability, design your next great adventure: mastery through real audiences, mentors and internships, graduating with a portfolio and a public Launch Plan.



Watch: Studio Shorts (30-45s each)

A quick look at each studio - watch your child's, or each of your children's.

★ This Year's Journey - by Studio, 2026-2027

Every studio walks the same Hero's Journey - at the scale that fits the learner. The Tots Tribe walks a parent-held threshold; Spark follows the seasons; Discovery and Adventure run Quests with a Civilization spine.

Tots Tribe - a threshold walked with a parent. *Not topical quests - a rhythm in two cycles.* Cycle 1 (Sessions 1-4), the parent recognition arc: Safe Base, Steady Hand, Witness, Held-Then-Let-Go. Cycle 2 (Sessions 5-7), the learner's Threshold Badges open (Community Service, Big Bathroom, Independence, Participation, Heart Awareness), leading to each tot's Pitch into Sparks.

Spark - following the seasons. 1 - Build the Tribe • 2 (Fall) - Geography & Our Community • 3 (Cozy) - The Body • 4 (Winter) - Music & Art • 5 - Debate • 6 (Spring) - Farm to Table • 7 (Summer) - Under the Sea.

Discovery: Y2 - Quests + Story of the World. 1 - Build the Tribe (Lip Dub) • 2 - E-Ship • 3 - Colonial Acton • 4 - Game Design • 5 - Marine Science • 6 - The Story of Energy • 7 - Growing Curiosity. *Reading spine: Story of the World, Vol. 3 - Early Modern Times.*

Adventure - Quests + Civilization. 1 - Friendship & Strategies for Life • 2 - Plan a Trip & Historical Speech • 3 - Trial of Socrates & Greek Myth • 4 - Apprenticeship • 5 - Biology I: Evolution & Hero Biography • 6 - Biology II: Medical & Research Funding Pitch • 7 - Art & Creativity. *Civilization spine: Big Bang • Ancient Greece & Rome • Athens & Socrates • Middle Ages • Guns, Germs & Steel • Tracing Goods • Deep Book Bio.*

Daily Life at Acton

Mon-Thurs (Tots Tribe Mon/Wed 9-11:30). Address: 14031 Silver Ridge Road, Caldwell ID. Non-urgent: BAND; urgent: call/text Jenna 208-204-8819.

- **8:30-8:45** Outdoor play & drop-off (all weather)
- **8:45-9:00** Brain Gym at the grassy field, announcements, a wellness exercise
- **9:00 Game Begins** **Work Block** - morning circle, music, town hall, goals; reading, math works, writing workshop, Socratic Launch, Quests, closing circle & reflection
- **Midday-2:00** Lunch & outdoor play, eaten outside (work block ends ~11:30 Tots / 12:30 Spark & Discovery / 1:15 Adventure)
- **by 2:00** Pick-up at the roundabout (starts 1:50)

How we start: "Good morning!" / "Yes it is!" - then Brain Gym, Heart Coherence, and the Wheel of Awareness. **Bring:** labeled water bottle, lunch & snack, backpack, weather layers.



Watch: A Day at Vibrant Life (60-90s)

The rhythm, from morning circle to pickup.

Calendar & Key Dates

Orientation Aug 4-7 • First Day Aug 17 • Last Day May 27. Seven sessions with a break between each (Sept 14-17, Oct 26-29, Feb 15-18, Apr 5-8), plus Thanksgiving Break Nov 23-27 and Winter Break Dec 21-31. No programs on Labor Day (Sept 7), Columbus Day (Oct 12), and MLK Day (Jan 18).

Full month-by-month calendar shared separately; exhibition dates confirmed in August.

✓ The Everyday: Food, Outside Play, Tech & Health

Food & water: nourishing food and a labeled water bottle daily; lighter on sugar (not "never"); different dietary philosophies respected. **Birthdays:** a Circle of Appreciation and a peacock feather for each learner.

Outside play: central, with managed risk - climbing, bare feet, muddy boots. We let learners assess their own risk; you'll hear from us about anything serious, not every boo-boo. An Outside Play Contract keeps it safe, with restorative steps. **Exhibitions of Learning** are living report cards - learners showcase their work and guides don't step in, because the exhibition is the learning.

"Encourage your child to have muddy, grassy, or sandy feet by the end of each day - that's the childhood they deserve."
- Penny Whitehouse • *"I took a walk in the woods and came out taller than the trees."* - Thoreau

Technology: a tool, not a toy - social-media- and game-free in studio, with safety filters. Tots screen-free; Spark guide-led; Discovery & Adventure sign a tech agreement and use a labeled Chromebook. **Health:** keep your child home for the symptoms in the onboarding guide; we trust each family's judgment. **Dress:** school-, weather-, and movement-appropriate.

☰ Studio Systems & The Words We Use

Studio Contracts (the learners' main governing document) • **V-Bucks** (recognizing responsibility and contribution) • **Badges** (mastery credentials, not prizes) • **Town Hall & 360 feedback.** **3 B's before G:** a learner tries their Brains, Books, and a Buddy before asking a Guide - who answers with leading questions, not the answer.

Student / Teacher	Learner (Hero) / Guide
Classroom / Classmates	Studio / Tribe mates
Grades / Report cards	Showing Mastery, Badges & Exhibitions
Worksheets / Textbooks	Quests, mentors & real-life experiences

Growth Mindset & Habits

This year (2026-2027), our community is reading *The Power of TED* (David Emerald) together. It teaches that "victim" is not who we are - it's a stance we can step out of: **Victim** → **Creator** (the hero mindset), Persecutor → Challenger, Rescuer → Coach. The point is the choice in the moment, not a label on a person.

Hero mindset (Creator)

Welcome challenges, embrace responsibility, celebrate excellence, practice kindness, hold firm boundaries.

Victim mindset (a stance we shift out of)

Avoid hard work, look for the easy way out, blame or make excuses - a pattern we can change.

Partner, don't rescue: when your child struggles, resist the urge to rescue - "What did you try? What's your next step?" Your calm is contagious.

Reflect with us: *When has a failure led to a greater lesson for you? Share it with your child. And - what makes a hero a hero?*

Keeping Score: Real Growth, Not Just Grades

We don't "keep score" like other schools. **Learners advance by readiness, not by birthdays.** Instead of grades, learners earn badges tracked in the online Journey Tracker. Learning is self-paced - **the only comparison is you, yesterday.** When readiness thresholds are met, a learner prepares a Pitch to the Next Studio.

Tools we use daily: Brain Gym, Heart Coherence, the Wheel of Awareness, 4-7-8 breathing, tapping, aromatherapy, and a Living Library of "living books."

Reflect with us (a weekly habit to share): *What was your achievement this week - and your failure? When did you serve as a guide to someone, and who guided you?*

Forming a Team: What We Ask of You

We want VL to be a connecting place for the whole family. Choosing Vibrant Life is a family commitment, not a drop-off.

- ★ **Be reachable** during the day for a bathroom need or a moment of extra support.
- ★ **Join the community** - a volunteer team and the Skills directory.
- ★ **Come to parent meetings & Journey Meetings** - quarterly parent meetings (at least 3 of 4), and your learner's goal-setting conference twice a year (around Sessions 2 & 5), ideally both parents.
- ★ **Partner, don't rescue;** let your learner fail early, cheaply, and often.

★ **Bring an all-weather mindset;** use BAND and Open Forums / nonviolent communication.

★ **Provide gear & a device** - outdoor layers, plus a Chromebook for older studios.

If it's ever not the right fit: we talk it through first - two meetings with the guide and two with Jenna - and part ways, if we must, with grace. Current-month tuition is prorated and refunded.



Watch: What We Ask of You (60s)

The honest commitment - so you can decide if it fits your season.

We're here to raise self-governed humans - young people who know their purpose, work for themselves, and choose courage and integrity when it's hard. The "win" isn't a GPA or a badge; it's a learner who can own their choices, repair quickly, think creatively, serve others, and keep going - because character has been practiced, not preached, in a real community.

Find a calling, change the world.

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